



The Best Places to Eat Gong Bao Chicken

Alfresco restaurants in Dujiangyan inexpensive

For the best *gong bao* chicken experience in Dujiangyan, head to the host of waterside restaurants lining the overflow channel off Fuxing Road, just outside Lidui Park. Places here specialize in river food – including fresh frogs, snails, and little crayfish, all kept alive in buckets – but also include a broad range of Sichuanese favorites on the menu. The best way to choose a restaurant is to walk around and pick the busiest. The trick to finding a good plate of *gong bao* chicken (as it lends itself to endless variations, some better than others) is to look for one that includes chicken cubes, peanuts, Sichuan peppercorns, and chili peppers, and is not swamped in chili oil or sticky sauces. The best variations produce a relatively mild, dry dish with sharp, clear flavors. Whichever establishment you end up in, choose an outdoor table (most have awnings to protect you from the elements) and enjoy the setting, with the water racing roughly past along the broad, stone-lined channel. Make sure you check prices as you order, or you might get a shock when the bill arrives.

Around Lidui Park, Dujiangyan;
open dawn–dusk daily

In Chengdu

The excellent **Manting Fan** (+86 28 8517 7958; *moderate*) serves up first-rate *gong bao* chicken, alongside other Sichuanese favorites such as *mapo tofu* (soft tofu cubes in a hot bean sauce), smoked duck, dry-fried green beans, “fish-flavored” pork shreds, sweet rabbit threads with steamed buns, and sautéed bamboo shoots. **Lao Fangzi** (+86 28 8509 8822; *moderate*) has a similar menu, and their “mouthwatering chicken” is well worth a try.

Also in China

Baguo Buyi (+86 10 6400 8888; *expensive*) is the Beijing branch of a Chengdu chain, featuring excellent *gong bao* chicken, twice-cooked pork, and performances of Sichuan opera to enjoy with your meal. **Chuanguo Yuanyi** (+86 21 5836 8826; *expensive*) does the same job in Shanghai, while in Chongqing, **Waipo Qiao** (+86 23 6383 5988; *moderate*) serves some of the best Sichuanese food in town.

Around the World

In London, both the cooking and decor at **Barshu** (www.bar-shu.co.uk; *moderate*) are extraordinarily close to an authentic Chengdu experience. New York’s **Grand Sichuan** chain (www.thegrandsichuan.com; *moderate*) is well-regarded for staples including *gong bao* chicken. In Melbourne, aim for **Dainty Sichuan** (+61 3 9663 8861; *inexpensive*), a crowded, unsophisticated place that likes its spices.



Above Lanterns decorate one of the many small canals that are used to control the level of the Min River in Dujiangyan

Left *Gong bao* chicken combines chicken, peanuts, hot peppers, and Sichuan pepper with ginger and garlic in a light sweet-sour sauce